ESSENTIALS OF MIXING

Mixing might sound like preparing different types of salads with different ingredients. We can also finish the prepared salad by adding salad sauce. When it comes to salad sauces, there are numerous kinds and flavours to choose from.

Let us take another illustration. Have you noticed that when you listen to different types of music, the sound is always different? Please if you have not experienced this, then this should be your homework. Bring out your jazz, soul, hard metal, rock, salsa, meringue, Indian, Middle Eastern, African, etc., and listen for the sonic differences.

All that said, these genres of music are mixed differently for our listening pleasure. Now back to our salad. Mixing is like having a finished salad, nicely presented to you in a restaurant.

WHAT IS MIXING?

In ordinary music language, mixing implies matching the various elements (bass, synthesizers, pianos, cello, voice, and so on) **for each to be present** to make the best contribution to a song.[15]

WHAT IS A GOOD MIX?

Well, there is no single law about a good mix since there are different kinds of music and audio projects. Mixing is very subjective in terms of preference, but ultimately quality is the key.

One school of sound engineers would disagree as to whether a song is up to their taste but would agree about whether it is well produced.

Before we continue, let us define a 'bad mix'. A 'bad mix' indicates several errors, for instance, a bass line overpowering the others at a point where it obscures and dominates them. In addition, vocals could be indistinct and unclear or might be too high pitched, with unwanted noises and hisses.

Thus, **a 'good mix' is where clear-sounding parts can be distinguished from one another**.

- Where you can hear what is going on
- Where each element is demonstrated fully
- Where all sounds good
- Instrument lines can be heard.
- Highs and lows are evenly spread across the sonic spectrum.

We shall emphasize that a 'good mix' is the point at which.

- Each sound is just not clear but sounds great and stands up on its own,
- That encompasses great sounds spread across the frequency range.

DIFFERENT STYLES OF MUSIC AND MIXING

Surprisingly, your mix will not be appreciated in a different environment because of the style of music. For instance, if you mix club music, the bass and kick drum should be what needs to be heard and pounding the loudspeakers.

Genres like pop music are dependent on the voice and mid-range components for it to sound high for television and radio broadcasts.[16]

Method and Approach to Mixing Your Music Project

Most musicians or producers mix as they go common with electronic music productions whereas others leave everything to the last. Another group affords to get an engineer to handle mixing duties.

A tip

The fundamental questions in mind should be the following:

- Does your final product sound like a record / cd/ mp3 to a listener?
- Does it sound like your favorite cds or your favorite genre?

BASIC TOOLS AND TERMINOLOGY OF MIXING

Volume / Pan

Relevant of all the tools is the volume fader and pan pot. Pan pot is **equal left and right balances**, keeping in mind that a mix is a cautious and wise balance of sounds.

Compression / Limiter

This implies bringing down all highs and lows at certain points or thresholds, so that no signals will pass these thresholds.

Reverb

One of the headaches in music production is the inexistence of natural surroundings. Thus, the role of reverb units is to bring in a natural sounding effect to recorded music.

Equalizer

Sound engineers prefer to use the terms **low-range (bass), mid-range (mixture of bass and treble or high range), and high range (treble or high pitch or very loud).** The function then of the equalizer is to equate the basses, mid-ranges, and trebles to acceptable hearing frequencies.[17]

Longer wavelengths + lower frequencies = low sound / bass sound (numbing feeling)

Shorter wavelengths + higher frequencies = shrill, loud, high pitched treble sound (damaging to the ears)

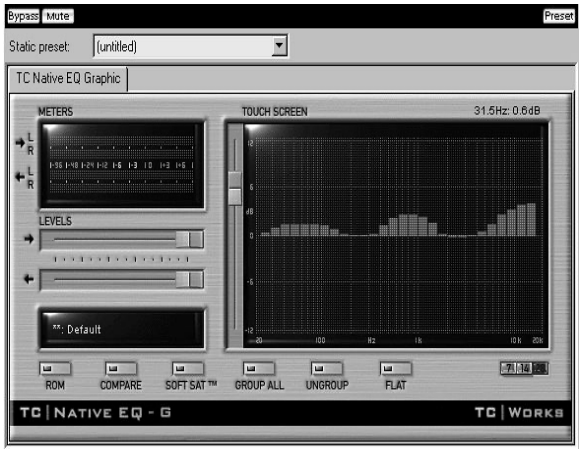
The equalizer is additionally for the following reasons:

- for acoustic dead rooms
- to correct the effects in our recordings because of our room's effects

How do we choose an equalizer?

Like the effects mentioned above for mixing our songs, the equalizer comes as software or hardware devices. Whatever form you adopt will do the work for you.

Remember to go for a quality tool when it comes to equalizers.

A software equalizer	A hardware equalizer
	

How do we adjust?

Before you start to turn knobs or move faders up and down, listen to your song before anything is undertaken.

Listen for too much bass, too highs or very loud sections, or noise or thumps that need taking out.

Apply these two basic and important rules:

1. **gently roll down the highest and lowest frequencies**
2. **enhance (gently bring up) the low and high frequencies or bring down the middle range.**

CHORUS

A great effect useful for mixing vocals, to give it depth, warmth, and a nice blend in a song.

DELAY

The delay effect is applied to let sound repeat itself in a rhythmic fashion in a repetitive pattern.

NEAR-FIELD MONITORS

To accomplish a professional quality mix, we would need to hear the process through near-field monitors. They give a clear and precise sound to your audio work, with a flat frequency response as possible.

AUTOMATION

- Adding emphasis

  In real-time, for example, when you are listening to your project, there will be sections missing. You can add more reverb or chorus to those parts as needed. With automation, you can make this happen by turning knobs and moving faders appropriately.

- *Fade-outs / fade-ins*

  Have you realized that a substantial number of songs on cds finish with a fade-out or start with a fade-in? For your surprise, even the experts do not know why this application came about. But it has been popular for over fifty years and is still used.

- *Copying parts*

  Most sequencers enable you to move the real-time controls along with any parts you are copying, and most will also allow you to copy just the automation data for use elsewhere in the project.